

TN.3 Inspection Sequence

Two inspection programs run over one Tennessee house — and only one of them stops when your county opts out.

Before you use this document

This is a process reference, not legal advice. Tennessee adopts one state residential code and then gives your jurisdiction three different ways to answer for it: run its own building department, let the State Fire Marshal enforce the state code through contract inspectors, or opt out entirely so that no residential building code is enforced at all. The unit is the **jurisdiction**, not the county — a city inside an opted-out county routinely has a different status from the county around it. What does not depend on any of that: the state electrical permit, the subsurface sewage disposal permit, and contractor licensing. Confirm every item with the office that will actually handle your parcel before you rely on it. The sequence below is the STATE program's, which governs SRBP jurisdictions. An EXEMPT jurisdiction runs its own schedule under its own adopted code; ask it, and write the answer on the log at the end.

WHAT YOU GET DEPENDS ON YOUR STATUS

TN.1 established which of the three labels applies to your parcel. Here is what each one means once the concrete starts moving. **Read down the electrical column.** It is the same in all three rows, and that is the point almost every Tennessee owner-builder misses.

Three statuses, two programs

Status	Who does the BUILDING inspections	Who does the ELECTRICAL inspections
EXEMPT 50 counties	The local building department inspects, on its own adopted code and its own schedule. Ask them for the list — it will usually be longer than the state's	Local, unless the jurisdiction is on the state electrical exempt list. Most are not
SRBP 8 counties	State contract inspectors, on the sequence fixed by rule 0780-02-23-.07 — the one set out below	State. Separate permit, separate inspector, separate fee
OPT OUT 37 counties	Nobody. No building permit, no framing inspection, no certificate of occupancy — unless you ask for one voluntarily	State. Still required. Every one of the 37 opt-out counties is inside the State Electrical Program

The building program rests on T.C.A. Title 68, Chapter 120 and rule chapter 0780-02-23. The electrical program rests on a different chapter entirely — T.C.A. § 68-102-113, § 68-102-143 and § 68-102-150, implemented at rule chapter 0780-02-01. The opt-out at § 68-120-101(b)(1)(B)(i) is written against "the standards established pursuant to subsection (a)" — the building standards. It does not reach the electrical chapter, and rule 0780-02-01 contains no opt-out mechanism at all.

THE STATE SEQUENCE, IN THE ORDER THE RULE FIXES IT

This is the whole of it, quoted. Note that the order is not advisory — a separate paragraph makes it binding, and forbids you from building past each point until that inspection has been approved.

Rule 0780-02-23-.07(2)(a) — Inspections shall be required on:

"1. **Foundations** after poles or piers are set or trenches or basement areas are excavated and any required forms erected and any required reinforcing steel is in place and supported prior to the placing of concrete... **Monolith poured slabs shall be inspected as the footing** for the structure.

2. ...**plumbing and mechanical systems** prior to covering or concealment, before fixtures or appliances are set or installed, and prior to or at the same time as the framing inspection.

3. **Frame** after roof, framing, fire stopping, draft stopping, bracing rough in plumbing, rough in mechanical and rough in electrical are in place.

4. **Attached garages.** 5. **Prefabricated walls.** 6. **Fire renovations.**

7. **Final** after the permitted work is complete and prior to occupancy."

And the order binds: "Inspections shall be conducted in the order set out in paragraph (2)... Work shall not be done beyond the point indicated in each successive inspection without first obtaining approval" (rule 0780-02-23-.07(4)).

*Read from the Secretary of State's official rule chapter 0780-02-23, "One and Two Family Dwellings and Townhouses", effective 25 February 2024, at publications.tnsosfiles.com. Two additions sit just below the quoted list: a **separate slab inspection** is required whenever the slab is not a monolith pour (rule .07(2)(b)), and "energy efficiency inspections shall occur during the required inspections" (rule .07(2)(c)) — there is no standalone insulation or energy visit.*

In practice that is three inspections on most houses, four on some. The State Fire Marshal's own guidance puts it plainly: "Three inspections will be required: the foundation prior to pour, the rough-in/framing, and at final construction. If your foundation is to be a concrete slab under a living space with separately poured footing, you will need a fourth inspection." Plumbing and mechanical are inspected too, at or before the framing visit.

THE INSULATION TRAP — IT DEPENDS WHICH KIND YOU BUY

This one costs people a whole inspection cycle, and it is decided at the builders' merchant weeks earlier. **Batt insulation must be IN before the framing inspection. Blown or sprayed insulation must be inspected BEFORE it goes in.** Same inspection, opposite instructions.

The rough-in/framing inspection, two ways

Insulation type	What the State Fire Marshal's guidance says
Batt or roll	"If batt or roll wall insulation is used, it must be in place prior to requesting an inspection. If a plastic vapor barrier is used, it should be installed <i>after</i> the inspection"
Loose-fill or spray	"If loose-fill or spray applied insulation is used, the request should be made before it is installed " — and a manufacturer's product data sheet and installation certificate stating the product meets or exceeds the energy code will be required

State Fire Marshal's Office, Residential Permit FAQs, page last modified 25 February 2026. The vapor barrier instruction is easy to skim past and is the reason a batt job sometimes fails on a second visit: the inspector has to see the insulation, so the plastic goes on afterwards.

THE ELECTRICAL TRACK RUNS ALONGSIDE, ON ITS OWN RULES

The State Fire Marshal says it in one sentence, and it is worth reading twice: "**The state residential building permit is a building permit only. It is not... an electrical permit.**" The same page lists four other things it is not — grading or fill approval, floodplain compliance, a septic or sewer permit, or zoning approval.

The electrical program, in four rules

	What the rule says	Cite
Where the permit comes from	"the power distributor, local building official, Commissioner, or designee, or other issuing agent authorized by the Commissioner." An issuing agent may charge no more than \$5.00 for issuing it, on top of the inspection fee	0780-02-01-.05(1)
Doing it yourself	"Any person may perform electrical work (for which an inspection is required) upon his/her own residence provided he/she first applies for and obtains a residential property owner's electrical permit. " It covers you and immediate family — no unlicensed helpers	0780-02-01-.05(2)(a)
A rejection costs a permit	An electrical rejection requires you to buy a new electrical permit. This is the opposite of the building permit, which carries one free re-inspection	0780-02-01-.05(6)
Power on for the final	"electrical power shall be supplied to the building in order for the inspector to perform the final inspection" — arrange the service release with the utility before you book it	0780-02-01-.04(11)

Two clocks, and they are different lengths

The **building** permit rule allows a property owner "only one (1) property owner's permit within a **twenty-four (24) month** period" (rule 0780-02-23-.05(3)). The **electrical** rule allows a residential property owner's electrical permit **once per twelve months** (rule 0780-02-01-.05(2)(a)). Twenty-four months and twelve months, in two different rule chapters, for the same house. If you are building a second dwelling — a shop with a dwelling unit, a parent's cottage — check both before you assume either.

The **electrical fee schedule is published in full**, which is unusual and useful. These are ceilings — the rule sets what the fee "shall not exceed."

Electrical inspection fees — rule 0780-02-01-.21

Inspection	Fee ceiling
Rough-in inspection, 0–1,000 amp	\$35.00
Final inspection, 0–200 amp	\$35.00
Final inspection, 201–400 amp	\$40.00
Final inspection, 401–600 amp	\$50.00
Re-inspection after a rejection	\$35.00
Inspection of a dwelling unit's heating and/or cooling system	\$35.00
Consultation inspection, optional and on request	\$50.00

A typical 200-amp house is therefore **\$35 rough-in plus \$35 final**, plus \$35 if the heating and cooling system is inspected, plus up to \$5 to the issuing agent. Rule chapter 0780-02-01, "Electrical Installations", effective 14 July 2025.

WHERE THE TWO PROGRAMS FINALLY MEET

They run independently for the whole build and then interlock twice at the end, in both directions.

- **The certificate of occupancy needs the electrical final.** "A new one (1) or two (2) family dwelling, townhouse... shall not be occupied until the Division has issued a certificate of occupancy," and that certificate "shall be issued after the passage of all inspections required by this chapter **and passage of the final electrical inspection**" (rule 0780-02-23-.09).
- **And the electrical final needs the building permit.** The electrical inspector "shall not issue a final certificate of approval on an installation **if a building permit has not been obtained, if required**... or all inspections have not been performed" (rule 0780-02-01-.04(10)). The words *if required* are doing the work: in an opt-out jurisdiction no building permit is required, so nothing is missing.

Turnaround, booking, failure and waiver

	The answer
How fast must they come?	"The law requires all inspections to occur within three working days of when the request is made to the inspector, except for footer inspections which are to be performed within one working day of the request"
Who books it?	The permit holder — that is you. The Fire Marshal's guidance is explicit: "Subcontractors should not schedule an inspection"
What does a failure cost?	"One re-inspection per permit may be performed without any additional fee. A second or subsequent re-inspection costs \$100 each"
Can any of it be waived?	Yes. "Any inspection may be waived if an inspection letter approving the work is signed and submitted by an Architect or Engineer currently registered with the State of Tennessee " (rule 0780-02-23-.07(5)). Worth knowing if you are using an engineer for a difficult foundation anyway

Inspections are booked at **core.tn.gov** — the Comprehensive Online Regulatory and Enforcement System, which is also where the permit is bought — or by email to the State Fire Marshal's permits mailbox with the full permit number and the date the work will be ready.

WHEN NOBODY IS REQUIRED TO INSPECT YOU

In an OPT OUT jurisdiction there is no building permit, no required inspection and no certificate of occupancy. **You can still ask for all three**, and there is a good reason to.

The voluntary inspection — and why a lender may make you want it

The statute creates the right expressly: "the owner of a building, structure, or premises located in a county or municipality that has taken action pursuant to subdivision (b)(1)(B) **may request that the state fire marshal inspect** the building... to determine whether [it] meets the statewide codes," and on passing, "the state fire marshal **must issue documentation to the owner evidencing such**" (§ 68-120-101(b)(1)(D)).

The State Fire Marshal's own page on opt-out jurisdictions gives the commercial reason: owners of one- or two-family dwellings "**may now be able to access lenders and loan programs previously unavailable to them because those lenders or loan programs required a CO.**"

Decide this before you pour, not after. A voluntary inspection is only useful if it happens at the stages an inspector can actually see — you cannot have a footing inspected through a finished slab. If there is any chance you will want the documentation, buy the permit at the start and run the normal sequence.

And the electrical inspections happen anyway. Whatever your building status, in all but a short list of jurisdictions the state electrical permit is required and a Deputy Electrical Inspector will come out at rough-in and at final. That is not optional and it does not depend on your

county's resolution.

INSPECTION LOG — RECORD EVERY ONE

Every visit, whoever required it

	Item	Date	Notes
☐	Foundation — forms and any reinforcing steel in place, before concrete. A monolith slab is inspected as the footing. Date _____ Inspector _____ Result _____		
☐	Slab , only if it is not a monolith pour and is under living space. Not required for a garage slab. Date _____ Inspector _____ Result _____		
☐	Plumbing and mechanical — before covering, before fixtures are set, at or before the framing inspection. Date _____ Inspector _____ Result _____		
☐	Electrical rough-in — state permit, separate inspector. Date _____ Inspector _____ Result _____		
☐	Frame — roof, framing, fire stopping, draft stopping, bracing and all three rough-ins in place. Batt insulation IN; blown insulation NOT yet. Date _____ Inspector _____ Result _____		
☐	Prefabricated walls , if any were used. Date _____ Inspector _____ Result _____		

Every visit, whoever required it

	Item	Date	Notes
☐	Attached garage , if there is one. Date _____ Inspector _____ Result _____		
☐	Electrical final — power must be on at the building for this one. Date _____ Inspector _____ Result _____		
☐	Final building — after the permitted work is complete and before occupancy. Date _____ Inspector _____ Result _____		
☐	Certificate of occupancy issued. Gated on the final electrical inspection as well as the building ones. Date _____ Number _____		
☐	Any inspection my EXEMPT jurisdiction requires that is not on this list — ask them, and write it here: Inspection _____ Date _____		

The rules are the part you actually need, and they are free. publications.tnsosfiles.com hosts them as dated PDFs — **0780-02-23** residential, **0780-02-01** electrical, **0400-48-01** septic — and the filename carries the effective date, so you can always tell whether yours is current. Statutes are published under contract by LexisNexis at lexisnexis.com/hottopics/tncode. **One warning:** building and electrical rest on separate authority — Title 68, Chapter 120 and Title 68, Chapter 102. Conflating them is why so many guides wrongly imply that opting out of the building code ends your permit obligations. It does not. Read September 2026.